

# 5 failure modes that quietly kill AI adoption programs, and the early-warning sign for each

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# 1. Pilot purgatory.

The pilot never ends, because the charter never gave it a way to end.

*Warning sign: no kill condition, no dated decision, silent renewals.*

## 2. Tool sprawl.

AI tools multiply across teams while nobody can list what's in use or what it costs per active seat.

*Warning sign: new tools show up in expense reports you didn't approve.*

## 3. Productivity theater.

Activity metrics light up. Value per active seat stays flat.

*Warning sign: the deck shows logins and licenses, not outcomes.*

## 4. Cognitive debt.

People offload the thinking to the assistant and ship confident wrong answers.

*Warning sign: rework climbs and nobody's tracking it.*

## 5. Champion burnout.

Every thread runs through one person, so the program's memory walks out the door when they do.

*Warning sign: you're the only one who can answer 'what's connected to our assistant.'*

# Score your program on all five, every quarter.

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The self-assessment ships in The AI Champion's Playbook, 2nd edition.

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